and family, and on the evening of his departure he has embraced and kissed your elder son on your behalf.'[201]

Decades ago, I was fortunate to see, in the possession of VOC's son Subramaniam, an exquisite marble plaque with a portrait of VOC and his wife Meenakshi imprinted on it—a gift by an Italian sailor. Evidently, VOC made friends and won admiration across racial barriers.

It would be harsh therefore to describe these transactions as unprofessional—too much had happened in too short a time and against the greatest odds. To blame the inexperienced Swadeshis for their failings would be unfair.



The situation seemed hopeless towards the end of 1908. In writing to VOC in early October, the head accountant V. Sankaraiah's comment, 'All our office staff are doing well. The company is working satisfactorily but the financial difficulty is still in existence', was only softening the blow.[202]

By October, the district superintendent of police was declaring that the company was 'now absolutely on its last legs'. The *Ipswich* had returned to Bombay as SSNCo could not pay for it which may have actually been a relief. The *Gallia* continued to be laid up in Colombo while the *Lawoe* was making the odd trip to Colombo.[203]

By the next month, there were reports that the *Lawoe* also had ceased to sail. It was moored in Colombo harbour because Delmege Fonseka and Company had refused to supply coal on credit. So critical was the situation that the SSNCo's directors even considered negotiating with some Ceylon merchants for the transfer of the company.[204] K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, accompanied by another Tuticorin pleader, P.V. Ganapathi Pillai rushed to Colombo to settle the matter, with S.D. Krishna Aiyangar following them on their return on 30 November—with what results is not known.[205]

In this context, many of the directors were in favour of winding up the company. C. Vijayaraghavachari was a prominent dissenter who argued for 'hang[ing] on at all costs' and promised to get money from some